Before the finals, the atmosphere got a little heated again when Ricky Ponting declared that Australia would have to play only the first two of the three finals, as that was all it would take to send India packing. His comments only added to our determination.

Australia batted first at the SCG after winning the toss. It's usually a sensible ploy to bat first in a big final, because even a mediocre score can be made to look good in a must-win situation. Australia made 239 on the day, with Matthew Hayden contributing 82, and we didn't think it was a bad total in good bowling conditions.

Robin Uthappa was opening the batting with me and our first task was to see off the new ball. We knew that if the team batted our full fifty overs, we should win the match, and I advised Robin to be patient and not to be aggressive early in the innings. Being a naturally attacking batsman, Robin was itching to play his shots and at one point I had to get a little angry with him, telling him not to do anything rash. We managed not to lose a wicket until the eleventh over, when Robin played his first big pull shot to deep square leg, where Mike Hussey caught the ball low down. Robin might have scored only 17, but he had helped see off the new ball and we had put together a 50-run first-wicket partnership.

I sensed that the match would be ours if we kept our nerve. Unfortunately for us, we lost Gautam Gambhir and Yuvraj within a few overs and needed another partnership to rebuild the innings. Rohit Sharma had come out to bat and I asked him to play straight and not try any fancy shots early on. He batted brilliantly and soon we were in a position to grind down the opposition. Rohit finally got out to the all-rounder James Hopes for 66, just after I had reached my century.

Dhoni came out next and we knocked off the 30 runs needed to finish the match quite easily in the end. The only scare was a beamer from Brett Lee that hit me on the side of my helmet grille and the top of my left shoulder. The ball had slipped out of his hand and could very easily have injured me. I felt a little dizzy and jokingly suggested to Lee that he would have to answer to my son Arjun when he next went to Mumbai. Lee knew Arjun well and had spent some time with my family when we had filmed a *Boost* commercial together. He apologized immediately and the matter was put to rest there and then. It was an accident, of course, but the shoulder felt sore and the area between shoulder and elbow turned black.